Hamza Mohammad Syed

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Placement Director:	Matthias Doepke
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Doctoral Studies

London School of Economics
PhD in Economics 2022-2027 (*expected*)
MRes Economics, Merit 2020-22

REFERENCES

Prof. Sir Timothy Besley	Prof. Maitreesh Ghatak	Dr. Michael Callen
Department of Economics	Department of Economics	Department of Economics
London School of Economics	London School of Economics	London School of Economics
T.Besley@lse.ac.uk	M.Ghatak@lse.ac.uk	M.J.Callen@lse.ac.uk

Prior Education

Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics
MSc Economics, Distinction 2013-15

Hans Raj College, University of Delhi
BA Economics (Honours), First Division 2010-13

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics

Secondary: Political Economy, Energy and Environment, Applied Micro

Job Market Paper

Discrimination, Preferences, and Residential Sorting: Evidence from Delhi's Rental Housing Market

Abstract: Where a household lives shapes almost everything we care about: education, labour, health, environment, public services. But we observe segregation in several cities. Residential segregation is an equilibrium outcome of what households want and what the market will let them have, but the two halves are usually measured on different people. This paper measures both on the same households and neighbourhoods, using in-person surveys of 3,290 households and 619 rental brokers across Delhi through three randomised experiments. It finds that, *first*, changing an applicant's name from Hindu (majority) to Muslim (minority) lowers the probability of acceptance by about 22 percentage points, and almost all of that is outright refusal rather than a higher rent. *Second,* brokers report that a Muslim family could rent 24 of 100 local properties against 86 for an upper-caste Hindu family, and this gap is across the city. *Third,* when every option is stipulated to be available, 51 per cent of Muslim respondents choose a mixed or majority-Hindu neighbourhood, twice the share of the dominant upper-caste Hindu respondents willing to live outside their own group's areas. Combining the two measurements in a sorting model, the paper separates the constraint into its layers: 62 per cent of the access gap is attributable to landlords and resident associations and 38 per cent to brokers' own screening. Removing that excess would widen the accessible stock for Muslims by 25%, and enforcement directed at ten colonies would deliver half the benefit of enforcing everywhere. Equalising access would reduce segregation only modestly though, because the force separating the groups is the majority's avoidance of Muslim areas.

Working Papers

Power to progress: Electricity Supply, Inequality and Development in Rural India

Abstract: Does the same infrastructure improvement deliver the same development gains to communities held back by poverty as to those held back by social marginalization? I study this question for electricity reliability in rural Bihar, exploiting the structure of distribution networks in which supply is allocated at the feeder level so that all villages on a feeder receive the same hours. I use the caste and the income composition of the feeder as two instruments for village electricity supply. The first stage shows that feeders serving a higher share of Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe or low-income villages receive fewer supply hours. The central finding is that reliability produces *unequal* returns across forms of disadvantage. Economically disadvantaged villages translate greater electricity supply into gains in both farm and non-farm activity, together with positive effects on wealth. Caste-disadvantaged villages, facing the same institutional supply mechanism, exhibit gains concentrated in agriculture, with weaker non-farm outcomes and no corresponding wealth gains. A simple model rationalizes the pattern: electricity relaxes a *material* constraint that is binding on the income-poor but cannot relax the *social* constraint, exclusion from credit, markets, and non-farm occupations, that binds on the caste-marginalized. Infrastructure reliability alone may therefore be insufficient to reduce inequality when access to complementary opportunities remains socially constrained.

Work in Progress

What happens to convicted politicians? Evidence of a sentence for electoral crimes, *with Luiza Aires*

Ideological alignment and its impact on conflict

Teaching

London School of Economics, Teaching Fellow/Graduate Teaching Assistant:

- Quantitative Approaches and Policy Analysis, PP455 (Graduate) 2023-
- Economics in Public Policy, EC230 (Undergraduate) 2021-
- Macroeconomics II, EC2B5 (Undergraduate) 2022-
- Microeconomics II, EC2A5 (Undergraduate) 2022-23
- Probability and Statistical Inference, EC400 (Graduate) 2022-25
- Intermediate Microeconomics, EC201 (Summer School) 2024
- Introductory Microeconomics, EC101 (Summer School) 2025

Relevant Experience

Short term consultant at The World Bank 2022-23
Worked on pre-implementation data analysis for the evaluation on effect of mediators in case resolution in the Kenyan Judiciary
PIs: Dr. Anja Sautmann and Dr. Antoine Deeb

Research Manager at J-PAL SA 2019-20
Worked on implementation, fund-management, oversight, policy dissemination, and stakeholder management on the Energy and Environment portfolio at J-PAL South Asia
PIs: Dr. Michael Greenstone, Dr. Robin Burgess, Dr. Nicholas Ryan, Dr. Anant Sudarshan, and Dr. Prabhat Barnwal

Senior Research Associate at J-PAL SA 2017-19
Worked on implementation, data analysis, survey planning and oversight, scoping, and stakeholder management on Energy and Environment related projects
PIs: Dr. Michael Greenstone, Dr. Robin Burgess, Dr. Nicholas Ryan, Dr. Anant Sudarshan

Risk Analyst at HSBC 2015-17
Predictive modeling and model monitoring for credit risk scorecards for the APAC region

Awards, Grants and Scholarships

Weiss Fund Travel and Piloting Grant ($11k)	2025
IGC Small Projects Grant (Co-Investigator) (£5k)	2025
Hub for Equal Representation Grant (£5k)	2025
STICERD PhD Grant (£5k)	2025
IGC Small Projects Grant (£22k)	2024
STICERD PhD Grant (Co-Investigator) (£5k)	2024
STICERD PhD Grant (£5k)	2023
LSE PhD Studentship, London School of Economics	2020-25
LSE Economics Departmental Award, London School of Economics	2020-25

Presentations (* scheduled)

2026 19th Biennial Conference of the European Association for Comparative Economic Studies, The 8th International Conference on European Economics and Politics, Building for the Future: The Economics of Infrastructure and Sustainable Development Conference, 3rd Development Economics Workshop, Bihar Public Policy Days, World Environment Day ADRI Workshop, Advancements in Energy, Environmental, Development Economics and Finance Conference, OxDev 2026, World Bank and IGC Data and Knowledge in Housing Webinar, UKNDE2026*

2025 LSE-Warwick Political Economy Workshop; Political Science and Political Economy Seminar; Energy and Environmental Economics Seminar

2024 LSE-Warwick Political Economy Workshop

Languages and Skills

Languages: English (Fluent), Hindi (Native), Urdu (Native), Portuguese (Basic)
Software: STATA, SAS, R, LaTeX, Excel VBA, Python